‘All the best, Gunjan. Do everything right,’ Flight Lieutenant Kagti, who was the only officer there with the same seniority as mine, said to me as he walked past me to the helicopter that I was supposed to fly earlier. He was the one I had switched with.

‘I don’t know, I’m just nervous,’ I said.

‘You weren’t trained to be nervous,’ he said, and smiled before getting into the cockpit. I replied with a bleak smile. But he was right. I wasn’t trained to let nervousness jeopardize a mission. I did not pass out from the academy with flying colours just to get nervous. I was very much capable of pulling it off, I assured myself. With this as a reminder, I got inside the cockpit as soon as the captain arrived.

‘I hope your photographic memory serves you well today. Now let’s get to the start-up procedure,’ the captain said, as he strapped himself to his seat. He noticed that I was a bit shaky in my start-up procedure. He could see that I was still nervous. And there was no denying that I was.

And then we took off. We orbited over Srinagar to gain height up to 5000 feet for vertical clearance from small arms fire or shoulder-fired missiles. During the climb, I mentally shook myself and told myself I couldn’t be jittery about this any more. Pulling myself together, I took out the map, took the bearings, did my calculations for timing based on the ground speed, adjusted our ETA and switched on the stopwatch to ensure I did not overshoot our position. As per standard operating procedure, if we failed to spot our helipad by the calculated time, we were to return without completing the casevac, because hovering was prohibited in that area due to the dangers involved. And I did not want to deprive a casualty of a chance at getting proper medical aid. The life of a soldier was at stake, and I did not want to fail. I was responsible for navigating and finding the helipad. Failing to do so, I would be held responsible for the unsuccessful sortie and my experience of flying in this area would go in vain. Not only this, my flight commander’s faith in me would be shaken.

As we entered the valley, I concentrated only on the navigation. After only a few minutes, the stopwatch indicated that the turn had come. But I couldn’t identify it as I looked down at the valley, and it made me nervous.